



Professional Skills I: Presenting All Techniques

Basic Techniques

Concentration - ability to enter a state of embodiment without interruption from the language-based, intellectual mind

Relaxation - ability to use only the muscular energy needed at any given time, no more and no less

Meaningful gesture - specific use of physicality / gesture to support the clarity of your storytelling (as opposed to random, vague or meaningless gesture born from a lack of concentration / relaxation)

Home bases - a form of meaningful gesture; "resting" postures for a character

Breathing, gazing, grounding - tools for practicing concentration and relaxation

Theatrical Sphere of Expression - the distance we need to fill physically and vocally to be clearly seen, heard and understood in a theatrical space

Phrasing - the technique by which a speaker breaks up memorized text into understandable units (i.e. phrases); proper phrases are created by breathing in through the mouth at the punctuation, then speaking the phrase on the exhalation

Acting the behavior of thinking - together with our phrases, we must act out the behavior accompanying the character's thought process

Vocal variation - the technique by which a speaker keeps a listener engaged; the technique by which a speaker helps the listener understand the content and structure of a speech; the technique by which an actor makes distinct, dynamic shifts in vocal and acting choices from phrase to phrase

Point of view - the technique by which we name the character's relationship to what they are saying in a given phrase.

Introspection / communication - any point of view can be played in one of two directions: an introspective acting choice has the quality of still being in process, or more for the

speaker than for the listener; a communicative acting choice has the quality of being fully processed and for the listener more than the speaker

Vocal Dynamics - pitch, rhythm and volume

Techniques from Shakespeare

Linking / liting inflection - adding "movement" to the end of the phrase to indicate to the listener that we're at a comma, as opposed to a period

Conclusive / upward inflection -- adding emphasis to the operative syllable of the last operative word to indicate to the listener that we're at a period, without deflating the text

Subordinate clauses - dropping the pitch so the audience can hear the difference between the subordinate phrase and the primary phrase

Big little words -- endowing words like "but, yet, or, however" with a great deal of "movement" to help the listener hear the work the word is doing in order to change the direction of the thought

Techniques for Public Speaking

Meaningful eye contact - using gazing to make eye contact with one member of the audience at a time, taking care to include folks at the edges of the audience, and not just the folks in the center

Redefining - clarify words like "this" and "that"

Vocal highlighting – enunciate key terms and vocabulary words

Speak in a conversational tone - use the mature part of your voice and engage the audience as you would a single listener, avoiding any quality of "reciting"

Hesitation - build a slight hesitation into your words to create a sense of organic language

Upward conclusive inflection - move the operative syllable of the last operative word in the sentence forward and up in terms of pitch and volume, instead of down and back